



Shwedagon Pagoda

△ **Statue of Buddha** at the Shwedagon Pagoda, Myanmar

The Shwedagon Pagoda in Yangon, Myanmar's capital city, is a stupa (Buddhist reliquary) that was built to house eight of the Buddha's hairs, as well as other relics. It is one of the most sacred Buddhist pagodas and, with its gold plating and precious stones, is also one of the most opulent.

The pagoda rises 99m (326ft) from a hill above the city. The lower part is covered with 8,688 gold plates and the upper part with 13,153. The top of the stupa, too high to see clearly from the ground, is set with 5,448 diamonds, a mixture of 2,317 rubies, sapphires, and other precious stones, and 1,065 golden bells. It is tipped with a huge 76-carat diamond.

The stupa dazzles in the sunshine and emits a golden glow when illuminated at night. It is traditionally said to be 2,600 years old, making it the world's oldest stupa, although evidence suggests it is more recent, possibly from around 6th–10th

centuries CE. According to legend, two brothers, merchants from Balkhin



Pagoda with the Great Bell of Dhammazedi in the foreground, once thought to be the largest bell in the world. The bell has since been lost in the Yangon River, Myanmar

(in present-day Afghanistan) met the Lord Gautama Buddha and were presented with eight of his hairs, which they later brought to Burma. With the help of local ruler King Okkalapa, they travelled to Singuttara Hill where three relics of other Buddhas preceding Gautama were also enshrined. The relics were placed in a chamber filled knee-deep with jewels, covered with a stone slab, and entombed when the stupa was built around them. Since then the pagoda has been rebuilt, ransacked, and restored, but throughout it has remained a crucial site of veneration.



Gold plating

Top of the stupa set with diamonds, rubies, sapphires, and other precious stones

Shwe Dagon dominates the city physically, aesthetically and spiritually

Win **Pe**
Author and artist

Key dates

6th century CE–2012

